

UPSC Civil Services (Main) Simulation GS-II

DETAILED SOLUTIONS / ANSWER KEY | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

Q1. Collective responsibility is both a rule of government survival and a rule of cabinet solidarity. Analyse with judicial support.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (146 words; practice model, not official): Article 75(3) makes collective responsibility central to Union parliamentary government in two senses. Survival: The Council must retain Lok Sabha confidence. A carried no-confidence motion requires resignation or a constitutionally proper dissolution route. Denial of essential supply is grave, though not every legislative defeat equals confidence loss. Solidarity: Ministers may disagree internally, but must publicly defend settled policy or resign. Parliament therefore confronts one accountable government. U.N.R. Rao (1971) held that dissolution does not terminate the Council: Article 74 preserves continuity while confidence can be tested only when a House exists. Shamsher Singh (1974) located responsibility in the advice-giving ministry. Subhash Desai (2023) required objective material of lost House confidence before a Governor-directed floor test; intra-party disagreement alone is insufficient. Thus, collective responsibility combines solidarity inside government with confidence before the House; it neither prohibits internal debate nor makes every lost vote fatal.

Q2. Examine the claim that e-governance projects carry a built-in bias towards technology and back-end integration rather than user-centric designs.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (96 words; practice model, not official): The bias is a predictable output of how government buys, staffs and measures technology rather than an occasional design lapse, so correcting it requires changing the procurement specification and the success metric, not exhorting designers to be user-centric. The Interactive Service Model is the model most exposed to the back-end bias precisely because completing a transaction end to end requires genuine process redesign whereas publishing information does not, so the reverse of the intuitive claim holds - higher maturity raises rather than lowers the design risk of a technology-push interface that is formally interactive and practically unusable.

Q3. Suggest measures to remedy the inadequate attention given to human-resource development in India.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (109 words; practice model, not official): Human-resource development fails at identifiable links rather than everywhere, so analysis should run the conversion chain, attach a measure to each failing link and end with a measurable safeguard rather than a general call for investment. Education is the second capability-conversion pillar after health, and the documented conversion frame runs from input, meaning access and resources, through process, meaning curriculum, pedagogy, teachers and infrastructure, to outcome, meaning foundational literacy and numeracy, higher-order skills and employability; the analytical consequence is that entitlement, quality and skills must all hold for schooling to become capability, so an answer that reports enrolment has reported an input and has not yet reached the question.

Q4. Distinguish federalism from administrative decentralisation and explain why India remains federal despite a strong Union.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (124 words; practice model, not official): Federalism constitutionally protects governments at two levels; administrative decentralisation grants powers that a superior government may ordinarily withdraw. India meets the federal test through a supreme written Constitution, dual polity, Seventh Schedule distribution, selective State ratification, judicial review and Rajya Sabha. States legislate directly on police, public health and agriculture; this authority is not delegated by the Union. The Union is stronger through Article 248 residue, Articles 249, 250, 252 and 253, Article 3, integrated services and emergency powers. These features qualify rather than erase federalism because they are constitutionally enumerated, conditioned and reviewable. S.R. Bommai protects federalism as Basic Structure. India is therefore a holding-together, Union-weighted federation. The decisive test is protected State competence, not equal institutional weight. Answer-prose count: 120 words.

Q5. Distinguish digital public infrastructure from e-governance with Indian examples and explain why the distinction changes the governance question.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (99 words; practice model, not official): Rails are reusable and cross-sectoral while a service is departmental, so the distinction converts a complaint about one portal into the systemic questions of interoperability, exclusion and concentration that the infrastructure layer actually raises. Digital public infrastructure means the foundational, interoperable digital systems built on open standards and application programming interfaces that enable identity verification, payments and consent-based data sharing at population scale for both government and private actors, and it is often called the India Stack; a specific departmental portal is a service built on those rails, so infrastructure and service are different objects with different governance problems.

Q6. Distinguish the three categories of right recognised by the Forest Rights Act, 2006, and explain what each secures.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (114 words; practice model, not official): The three categories secure tenure, livelihood and governance respectively, so the distinction must name the holder, the object and the limit of each, and must close on why the third is the least operationalised. The Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 recognises three categories that must be named separately: individual forest rights, community rights and community forest resource rights; available evidence indicates that examiners test precisely whether a candidate knows the third category, because an answer that describes the statute as a land-titling law has reduced a three-part recognition of tenure, livelihood and governance to its first part alone, and the recurring trap is exactly that reduction.

Q7. Distinguish the Inter-State Council, Zonal Councils, North Eastern Council and NITI Aayog by source, composition logic and function.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (141 words; practice model, not official): These bodies all facilitate coordination but have different legal foundations. The Inter-State Council is contemplated by Article 263 and was established by presidential order in 1990. Chaired by the Prime Minister, it advises on disputes and common policy; its recommendations are not binding. The five Zonal Councils are statutory bodies under the States Reorganisation Act, 1956. Chaired by the Union Home Minister, they address regional administrative and inter-State issues. The North Eastern Council is a separate statutory institution under the NEC Act, 1971; it is not a sixth Zonal Council. NITI Aayog was created by executive resolution in 2015. It is a policy and development forum, not a constitutional or statutory body and not a substitute for the Finance Commission. Thus, "intergovernmental body" does not establish legal status. Article, statute and executive resolution must be separately identified. Answer-prose count: 137 words.

Q8. Discuss the claim that democratic governance requires the public perception of the integrity and commitment of civil servants to be positive.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (107 words; practice model, not official): Perception is a legitimacy question produced at the counter rather than an image problem solved by communication, so the defensible position is that published standards, reasoned decisions, a named officer and working redress are the instruments that make integrity legible, while an unqualified demand for absolutely positive perception risks confusing legitimacy with popularity. Customer-satisfaction language imports useful service-design tools and can obscure that the citizen holds an entitlement rather than a preference, which is why remedy, reasoned decision and compensation matter more than a satisfaction score, and why standardisation must still distinguish routine from genuinely complex cases so that a uniform timeline does not become blind enforcement.

Q9. Distinguish the constitutional recognition in NALSA v. Union of India from the statutory scheme of the 2019 Act, and explain why the distinction matters in an answer.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (115 words; practice model, not official): 1. available evidence indicates that NALSA v. Union of India, decided by the Supreme Court in 2014, as the judgment recognising transgender persons' right to a self-identified gender under Articles 14, 15 and 21, directing welfare measures and directing that the government treat transgender persons as socially and educationally backward and consider extending backward-class benefits; the owners also record, as an advanced point, that the 2019 Act did not fully adopt that direction, and they instruct that no uniform national horizontal-reservation rule be invented, because the status of such claims remains a State and litigation question rather than a settled statutory entitlement. 2. available evidence indicates that on separating legal authorities that answers routinely blur.

Q10. An external attack affecting only one State does not mechanically trigger President's Rule. Explain the correct constitutional analysis.

[10 marks | 150 words]

Model answer (128 words; practice model, not official): Claim: Geography does not determine the emergency category. Article 356 applies only when State government cannot be carried on according to the Constitution. Named evidence: Article 352 instead addresses a grave emergency whereby the security of India or any part is threatened by war, external aggression or armed rebellion.

It permits a proclamation for a specified part and states no State-sized minimum. Analysis: A localised cross-border attack therefore requires assessment of Article 352's ground and security threshold. Article 355 may support Union protection, while criminal, policing and counter-terrorism law may remain sufficient. Terrorism is not automatically constitutional 'external aggression'. Qualification: The 2008 Mumbai attacks produced no National Emergency and no automatic Article 356 proclamation. Only independent proof that Maharashtra's constitutional government could not function would engage Article 356.

Q11. Critically examine the representative and sovereign character of the Constituent Assembly.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (220 words; practice model, not official): The Assembly's representative and sovereign character cannot be answered with one label. Under the Cabinet Mission scheme, its planned strength was 389: 296 British Indian and 93 princely-state seats. Provincial representatives were indirectly elected by community members of provincial assemblies through proportional representation by single transferable vote; princes nominated state representatives. The underlying provincial franchise was restricted. Congress won 208 of 296 seats, the Muslim League won 73, and the League boycotted the first sitting. These facts establish a real electoral and political deficit. Representation nevertheless had a deliberative dimension. The Assembly included religious minorities, Scheduled Castes, tribal members and women; specialist committees created channels on rights, minorities and excluded areas. Congress itself contained competing ideological and provincial tendencies. The prospective democratic answer was stronger still: universal adult franchise made the polity far more representative than the founding body's electorate. Sovereignty changed over time. The Cabinet Mission and British legal framework shaped the origin, so the criticism had force in December 1946. The Indian Independence Act 1947, however, removed external legal subordination, empowered the Assembly to frame any Constitution and repeal British statutes, and added legislative capacity. The Assembly was therefore not fully representative by modern electoral standards and was not equally sovereign at every stage. Yet post-1947 legal sovereignty, plural deliberation and universal-franchise output gave it qualified founding legitimacy.

Q12. Examine the claim that public charitable trusts have the potential to make India's development more inclusive because they relate to vital public issues.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (192 words; practice model, not official): The potential is real precisely where the state is procedurally slow, but it becomes inclusion only under disclosed governance, need-based targeting and a beneficiary route to complain, none of which the charitable legal form supplies by itself. A public charitable trust is a trust or endowment for a public charitable purpose governed through its trust deed, the applicable state public-trust or endowment law and general legal principles, and Section 1 of the Indian Trusts Act, 1882 expressly excludes public or private religious or charitable endowments, so that Act must never be cited as a uniform national incorporation statute for public charitable trusts. Any non-state development intervention is judged on additionality, that is whether it adds capacity or substitutes for a public obligation the state still owes; need-fit, that is whether the intervention was chosen from disaggregated local exclusion data or from the funder's priority; accountability, that is whether a beneficiary can obtain records, complain and force correction; sustainability, that is who finances and operates the service after the grant cycle ends; and federal or local fit, that is whether it is converged with the district plan or runs as a parallel silo.

Q13. Examine the universalism-versus-targeting choice in India's welfare design, including the errors that each design generates.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (211 words; practice model, not official): Neither design is costless, because universalism buys lower exclusion error with higher cost and inclusion error while targeting buys apparent efficiency with documentation barriers and exclusion risk, so the examination must argue the hybrid rather than declare a winner. Universalism provides the same entitlement to every member of a defined population and therefore reduces stigma and exclusion error while raising cost and inclusion error, whereas targeting concentrates resources on identified beneficiaries and therefore improves apparent efficiency while creating documentation barriers, identification disputes and exclusion risk; the two are not mutually exclusive and are best treated as a design trade-off rather than a moral contest, because Indian practice layers universal basic services such as elementary schooling and primary health on targeted transfers, scholarships, rehabilitation packages and affirmative action. Inclusion error occurs when a non-eligible person receives a benefit, which is the leakage that dominates political debate, and exclusion error occurs when an eligible person does not receive a benefit, which is the failure that dominates the lived experience of the poorest and is typically produced by documentation, seeding, migration and disability-related barriers; the analytical rule is that reducing one error usually raises the other, so a recommendation that promises to eliminate leakage without stating its exclusion consequence has not been thought through.

Q14. Examine India's simultaneous engagement with the United States, China and Russia during 2024 to 2026 as a test of hedging capacity.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (142 words; practice model, not official): Simultaneity is the empirical test of hedging, so the examination must date the three tracks within a single window, price the tariff cycle as a real but reversible third-party cost, distinguish exposure from obligation, and qualify the verdict with the installed-base dependence that the hedge has not yet removed. The twenty-third

India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; available evidence indicates that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

Q15. "India is federal in structure but possesses a pronounced centralising capacity." Discuss.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (194 words; practice model, not official): Indian federalism is a constitutional balance rather than a fixed label. Its federal structure rests on Union and State governments, a written and supreme Constitution, division of legislative competence, partial rigidity, bicameralism and an independent judiciary capable of resolving competence disputes. The Union nevertheless possesses strong integrative capacity. Residuary legislative power lies with Parliament; Governors are appointed by the Union; single citizenship, an integrated judiciary and All-India Services create common legal-administrative institutions; and Articles 352, 356 and 360 permit specified crisis centralisation. Article 1's phrase "Union of States" indicates that the Union was not created by an agreement among sovereign States and that no State has a right to secede. Operation adds two further dimensions. Cooperative federalism appears through institutions such as the Finance Commission, Inter-State Council and GST Council. Asymmetrical provisions, including the Fifth and Sixth Schedules and Article 371 series, accommodate distinct histories and communities. Strong Union capacity can coordinate national action and protect integrity, but Governor, fiscal and emergency practice can weaken State autonomy. Conversely, State power remains constitutionally real and judicially protected. India is therefore federal in structure, centralising in important instruments, cooperative in shared governance and asymmetric in accommodation.

Q16. Examine micro-finance as an anti-poverty instrument and the role of self-help groups in achieving asset creation and income security.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (185 words; practice model, not official): Micro-finance is strongest as a consumption-smoothing and vulnerability-reduction instrument and weakest as a structural poverty-exit instrument, so it works inside a livelihoods system of credit plus skill, market linkage and social protection and fails when treated as a substitute for it. India delivers micro-finance through two channels that must be kept apart: the savings-first self-help group and bank linkage route that builds a group balance sheet within the livelihoods architecture, and the specialised micro-finance institution and non-banking financial company route regulated by the Reserve Bank of India that builds a loan book, and the two carry different incentives even where they serve the same household. Micro-finance is the provision of small-value financial services including credit, savings, insurance and remittance to households excluded from conventional banking on collateral, documentation or transaction-cost grounds, and micro-credit is only one component of it, so the honest evaluative core is that micro-finance is strongest as a consumption-smoothing and vulnerability-reduction instrument and weakest as a structural poverty-exit instrument, because loan sizes suit micro-enterprise rather than asset accumulation and repayment discipline can be sustained by borrowing again rather than by income growth.

Q17. Assess whether India's food-security architecture has converted a discretionary scheme into an enforceable entitlement.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (190 words; practice model, not official): The statutory shift is real and is evidenced by the entitlement quantities, the life-cycle provisions and the food security allowance, but coverage identification, portability gaps and absorption failures limit it, so the assessment must be graded and must name the tier at which the claim fails. The National Food Security Act, 2013 provides a statutory entitlement of five kilograms of foodgrain per person per month for priority households and thirty-five kilograms per household per month for Antyodaya Anna Yojana households, and the Department of Food and Public Distribution's own portal, read on 2 September 2026, records that the Act was enacted on 5 July 2013, that it marks a paradigm shift from a welfare to a rights-based approach, that it legally entitles up to seventy-five per cent of the rural population and fifty per cent of the urban population to receive subsidised foodgrains under the targeted public distribution system, that it is implemented in all States and Union Territories, and that out of a maximum coverage of 81.34 crore persons around 80 crore persons are covered at present, with identification treated as a continuous process of exclusion and inclusion.

Q18. Examine the instruments through which India converts the SAGAR doctrine into island-state partnership, and state what those instruments do not establish.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (146 words; practice model, not official): Every instrument is real, dated and bounded, so the examination must move from the doctrinal statements of 2015 and 2025 through the Joint Vision of 7 October 2024 and the Conclave participation categories of 20 November 2025, and close by refusing to convert a vision document, an arranged facility or an observer seat into a guaranteed outcome. SAGAR, standing for Security and Growth for All in the Region, is India's declared maritime vision for the Indian Ocean Region articulated in Mauritius on 12 March 2015, combining security cooperation with economic and developmental partnership for littoral and island states; available evidence indicates that its evidentiary level precisely as a declared vision guiding regional maritime

engagement and not as a binding treaty or alliance, so an answer must call it a doctrine or vision and never a legal instrument creating obligations on India or on any partner state.

Q19. Article 368 reaches the Preamble, but the basic features declared in the Preamble do not yield to Article 368. Critically examine.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (195 words; practice model, not official): The statement captures the distinction between constitutional amendment and constitutional destruction. Article 368 reaches the Preamble because Kesavananda Bharati (1973) held the Preamble to be part of the Constitution. Parliament consequently altered its text through the 42nd Amendment, 1976, inserting Socialist, Secular and Integrity. Dr Balram Singh (2024) reaffirmed that the adoption date does not freeze the Preamble against amendment and dismissed the challenge to Socialist and Secular. Yet the amending power is limited. Kesavananda held that Parliament cannot damage the Constitution's basic structure, whose identity is illuminated by Preambular commitments such as sovereignty, democracy, republicanism, secularism, liberty, equality and dignity. Minerva Mills (1980) reaffirmed limited amending power and constitutional balance; S.R. Bommai (1994) applied secularism as a basic feature. The criticism is institutional: the text does not enumerate every basic feature, so judicial identification may appear counter-majoritarian. The reply is structural. If an amendment majority could abolish the democratic or secular identity from which its authority arises, Article 368 would become a power to replace rather than amend the Constitution. Therefore wording may change and commitments may be clarified, but the Preamble cannot be used to authorise the legal destruction of constitutional identity.

Q20. Examine the claim that a social audit produces answerability but not necessarily enforceability.

[15 marks | 250 words]

Model answer (182 words; practice model, not official): The claim holds because the public hearing compels a public explanation while imposing no sanction of its own, so social audit reliably produces answerability and produces enforceability only where a mandated action-taken process couples it to an instrument that can recover, discipline or prosecute. At a public hearing the audit findings are presented in an open forum in which officials must respond in front of the affected community, which creates a direct, on-the-record answerability event that a written information reply cannot produce; a hearing that surfaces a discrepancy without a mandated corrective timeline nevertheless achieves answerability without enforceability, which is the distinction that decides whether social audit produces deterrence or symbolic transparency. Two questions decide social-audit quality - whether the facilitating unit is structurally separate from the department whose work is audited, and whether a finding triggers timed recovery, disciplinary, criminal or process-correction action - and applying these two tests converts a generic call for more transparency into a precise diagnosis; mandating follow-up strengthens deterrence and can also produce defensive behaviour such as under-reporting and resistance to audit access unless honest officials are protected.

END OF DETAILED SOLUTIONS